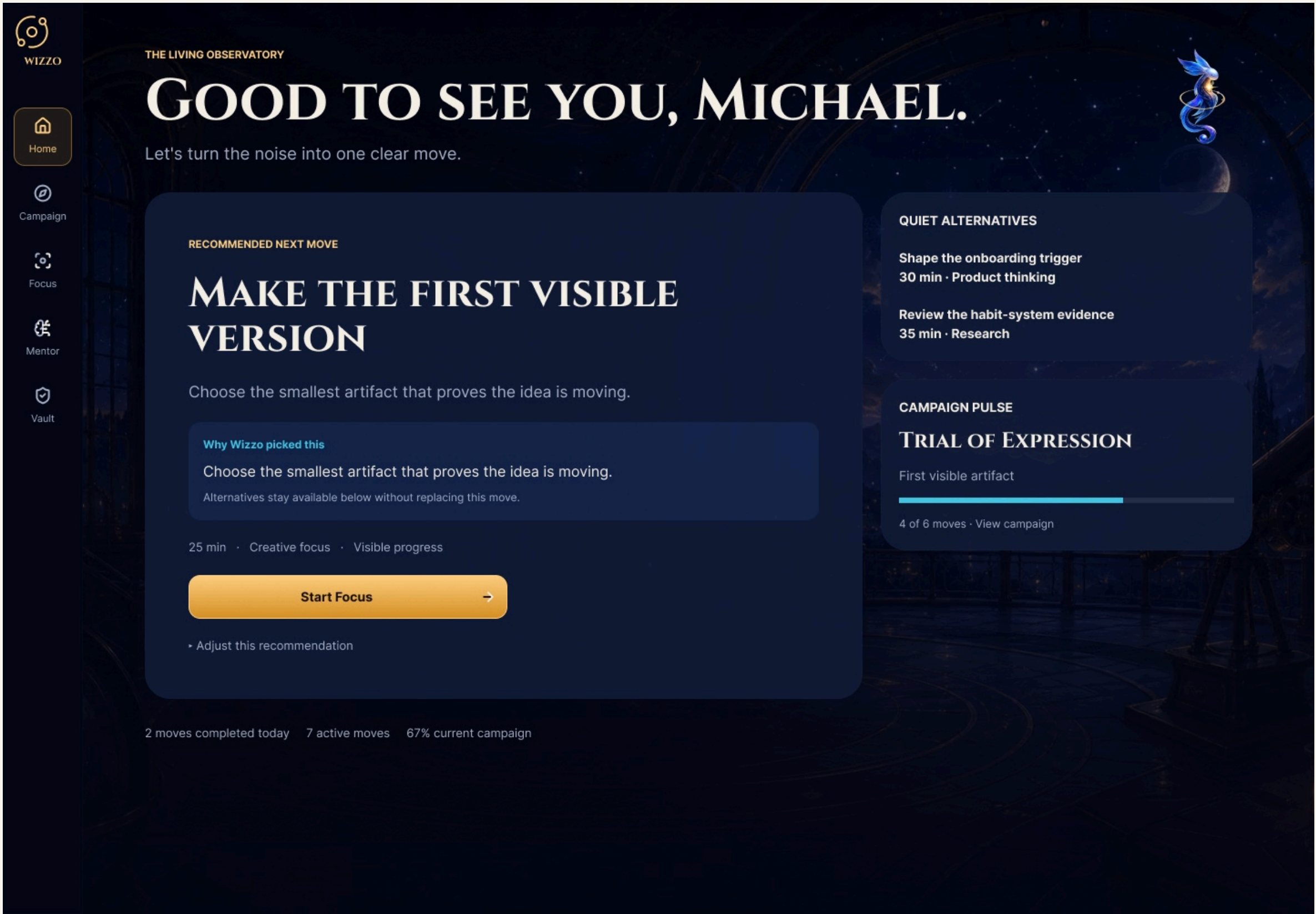


Give ambition a clear next move.

Product direction, interaction design, visual identity and a living system.



Wizzo helps a person turn a broad goal into a concrete action they can begin. I shaped the experience around a clear hierarchy, deliberate commitment and an identity that makes progress feel alive.

My responsibility

Founder-led product and visual direction, interaction design, implementation and acceptance.

The experience

A Living Observatory: one recommended move, editable commitment, focused work and visible progress.

Functional was not enough.

A founder's assessment of the original product.

"The original Wizzo was functional, but it felt too generic to me. It did not express the identity or sense of direction I wanted the product to have."

What I wanted to change

Advice needed a stronger destination: a useful action, a visible place in a Campaign, and a clear way to begin.

The design response

Give the next action the strongest hierarchy. Make control visible. Use the observatory and Wisp as a coherent identity, with reusable rules across surfaces.

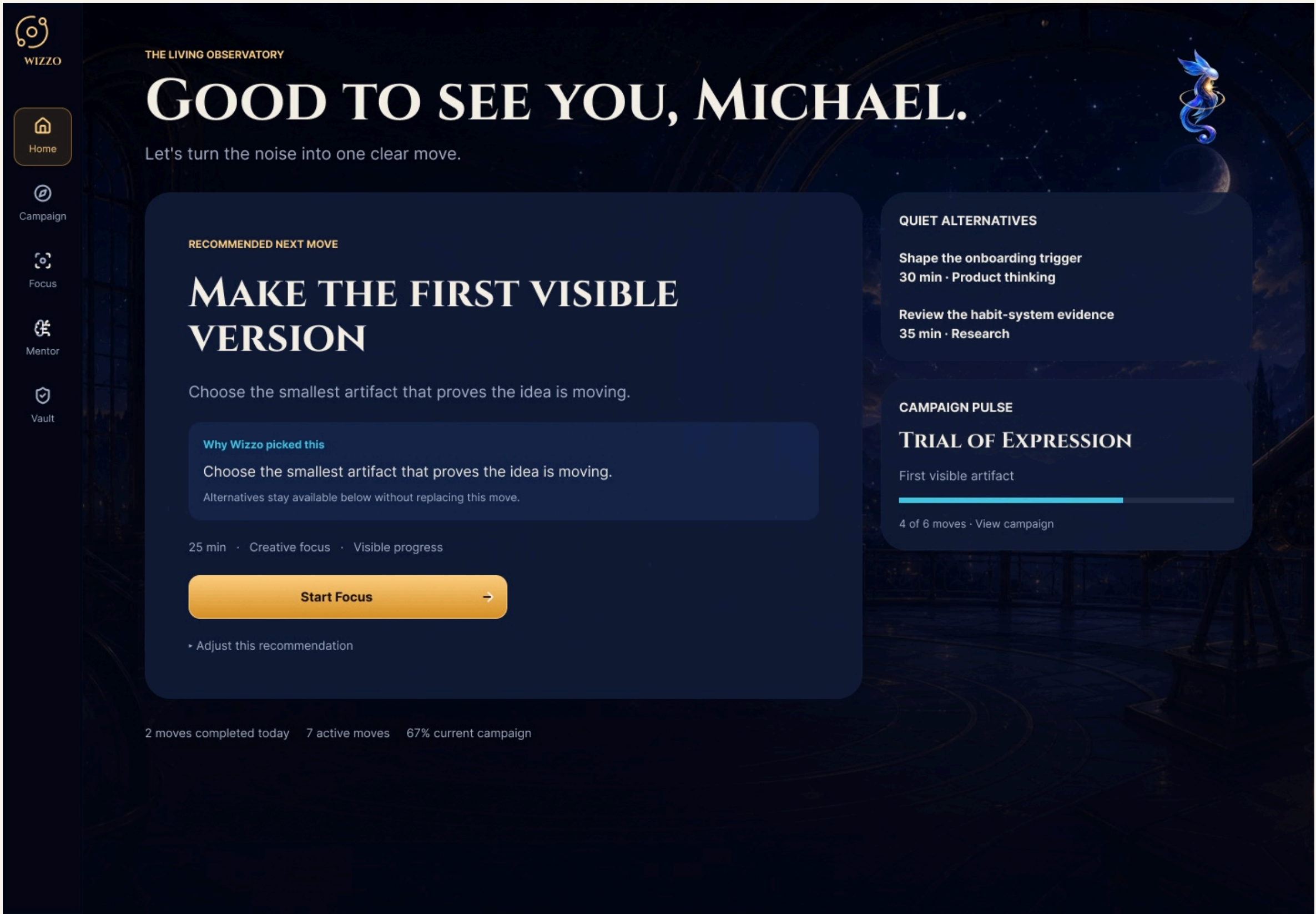
The standard

Distinctive enough to feel like Wizzo; restrained enough that the task still leads.

Founder assessment. Not a comparative research finding.

How does the next action become clear?

Home: recommendation hierarchy.



The Next Move is the center of gravity. Its title says what to do; supporting copy makes the result concrete; duration frames the commitment. A warm primary action marks the point of entry.

Primary

Begin the recommended move.

Supporting

Understand the reason and the commitment.

Peripheral

Keep up to two alternatives and Campaign progress available without giving everything equal weight.

An observatory, not a dashboard of equal cards.

Depth, contrast and typography have specific jobs.

The dark environment gives the experience a recognizable setting. Opaque-enough panels create quiet reading surfaces. Warm amber is reserved for action; cyan supports context and instruments. Cinzel supplies display character while Inter carries working text.



Canvas

#050816



Panel

#091326



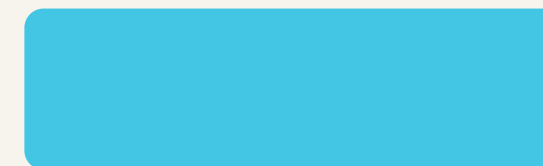
Elevated

#111c38



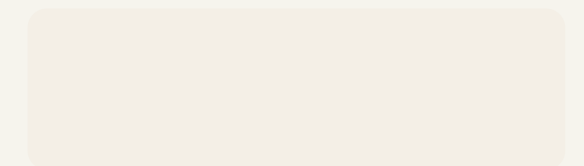
Action

#f0ae42



Context

#42c7e5



Primary text

#f5f0e6

Tradeoff

Atmosphere builds identity, but can reduce clarity if every element glows or moves.

Control

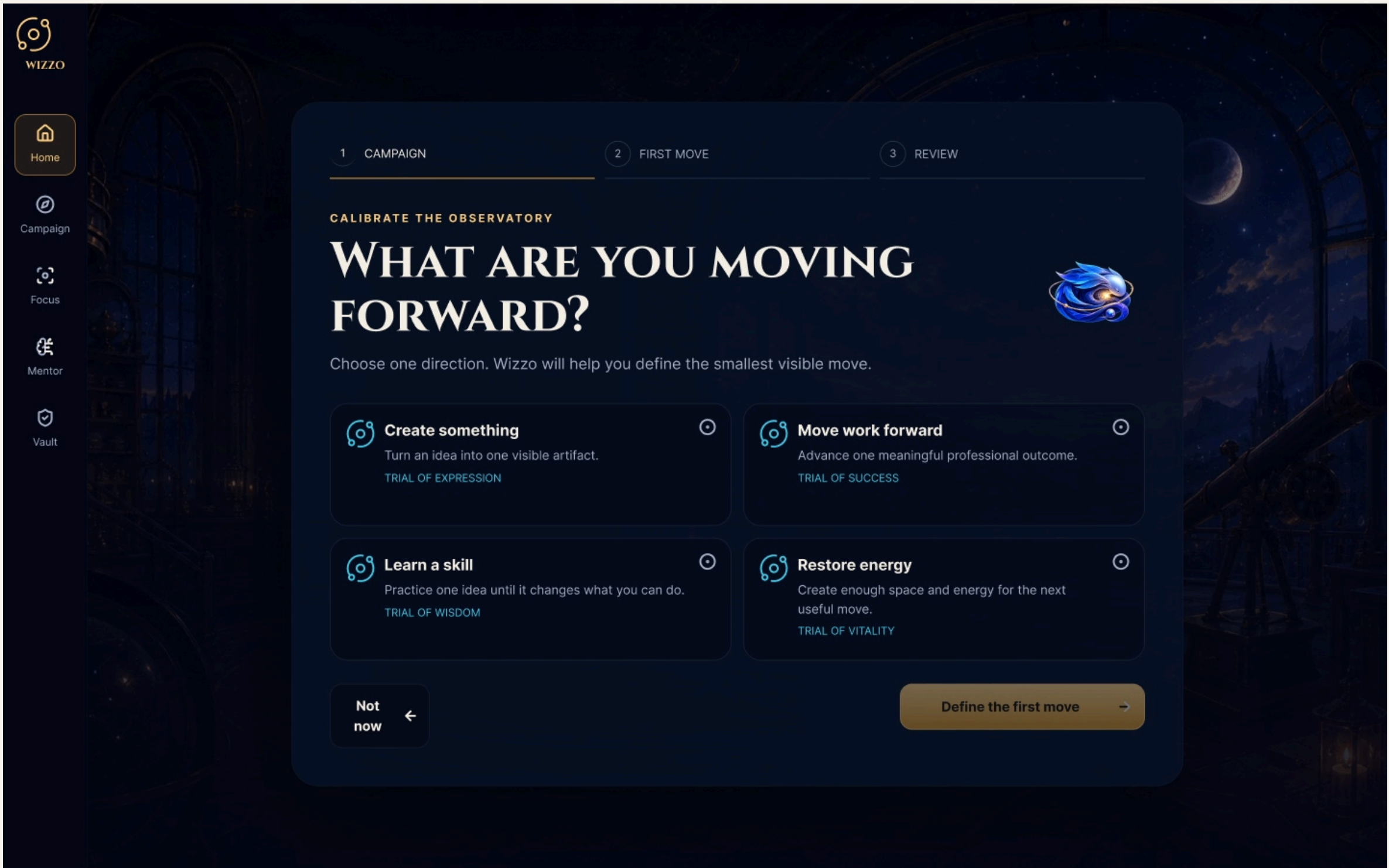
Keep the primary action legible, the type hierarchy limited, and decorative detail behind the content.

Consistency

Use shared color roles and surface rules rather than tuning each screen independently.

What should remain editable?

Onboarding: selection, review and confirmation.



Onboarding asks for a direction before the first concrete move. Selection gives a Campaign context; the next step defines the result and duration. Review keeps those choices legible before anything is saved.

Keep the burden small

Choose one direction, one visible result and one focused duration.

Make selection visible

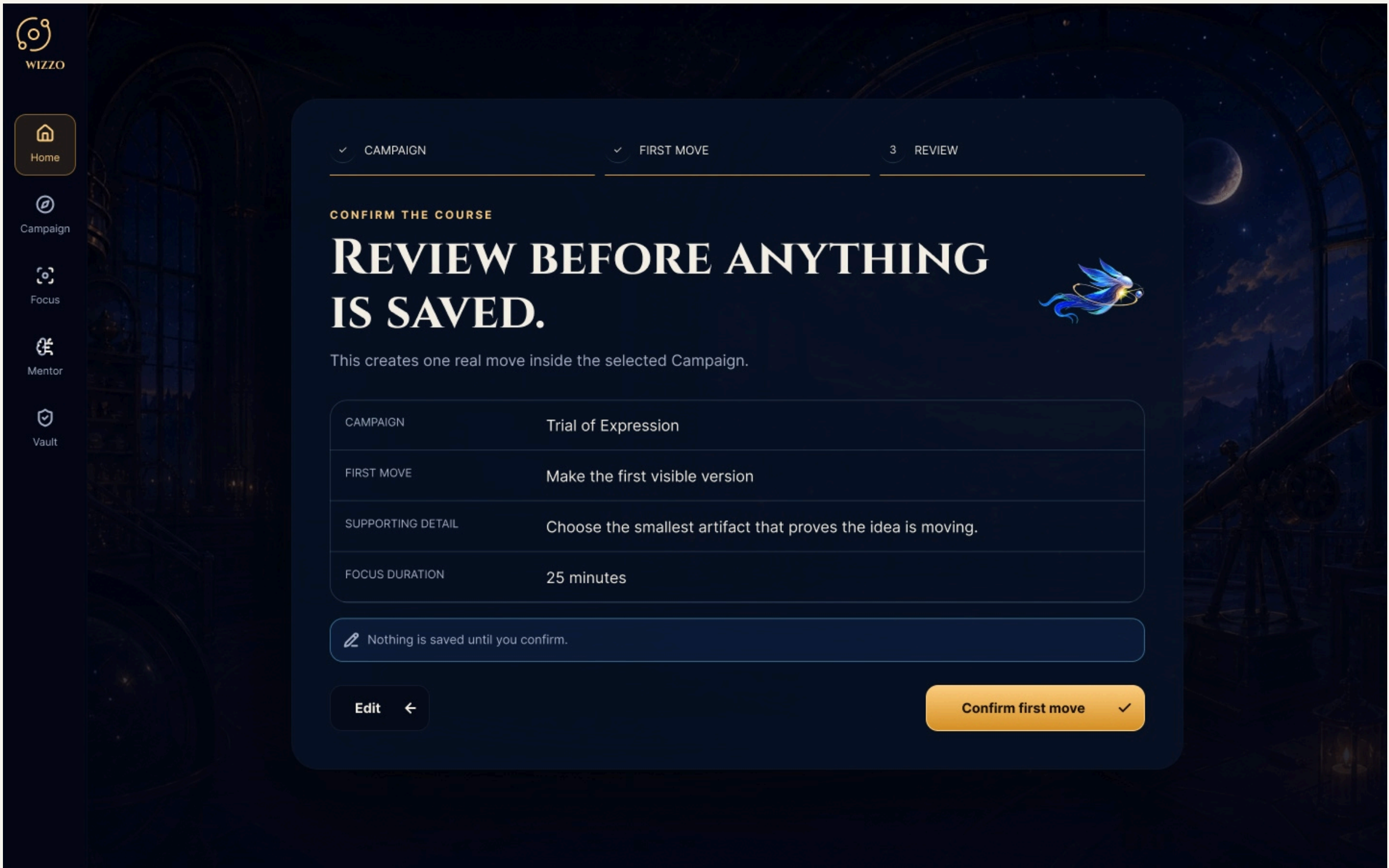
The selected card changes border, indicator and state, so selection does not depend on color alone.

Tradeoff

A review step adds effort. It earns its place by making commitment explicit and giving editing a predictable home.

Review the commitment, then confirm.

Values remain visible and editing has a clear return path.



Review brings the Campaign, action and duration together. Back returns to editing without turning a change of mind into a restart. Confirmation is a deliberate action with a busy state while the result is being created.

Before save

Explain what confirmation will create.

While saving

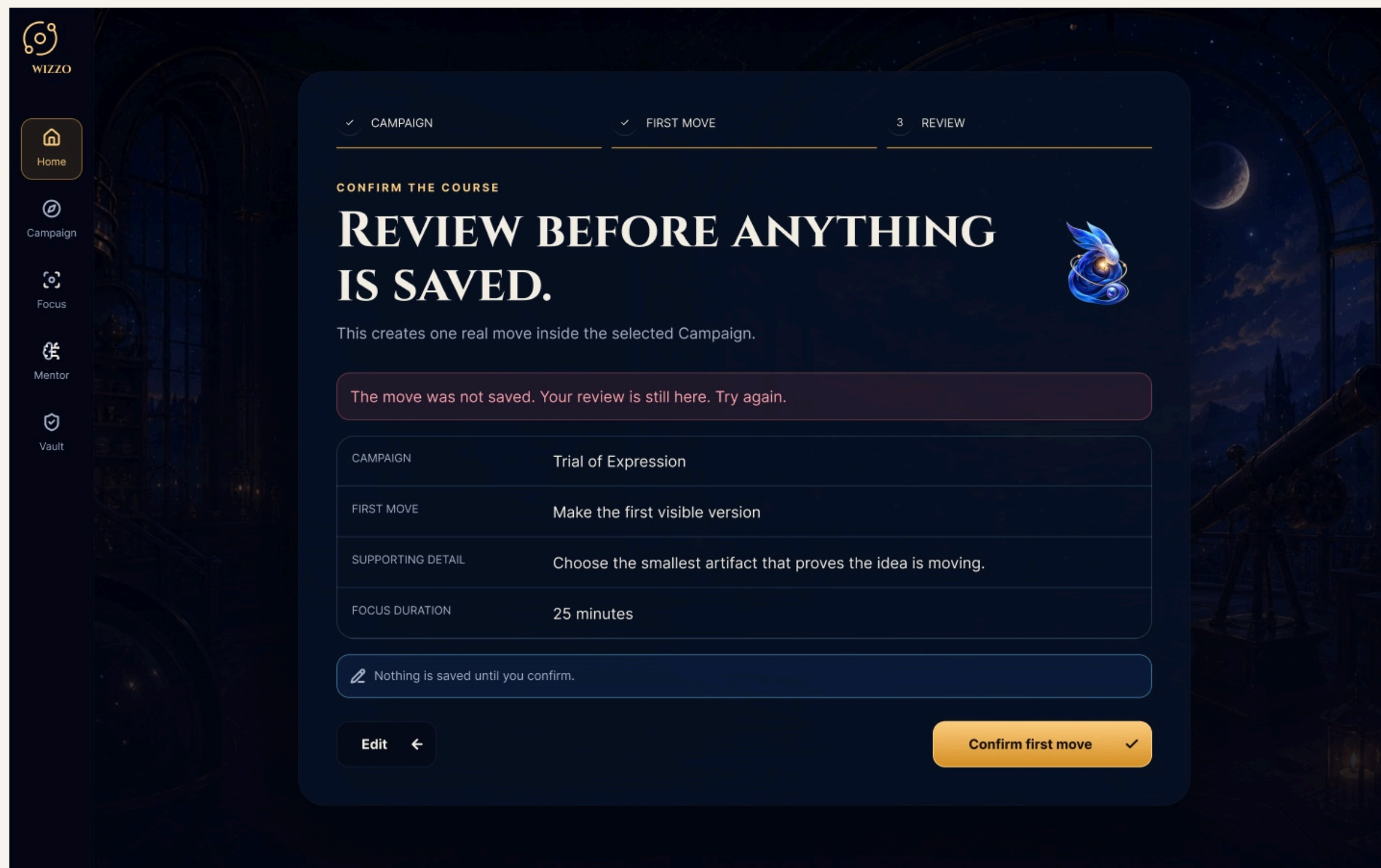
Use an explicit busy label and prevent a duplicate action.

After save

Describe the actual result and offer the appropriate continuation.

A failure should not erase the decision.

Recovery: retained context and a specific next action.



A failed save is still the same review, with the same intended move. The error belongs near the action and should say what did not happen. The person can retry or return to editing instead of reconstructing the form.

Preserve

Keep Campaign, action and duration visible.

Explain

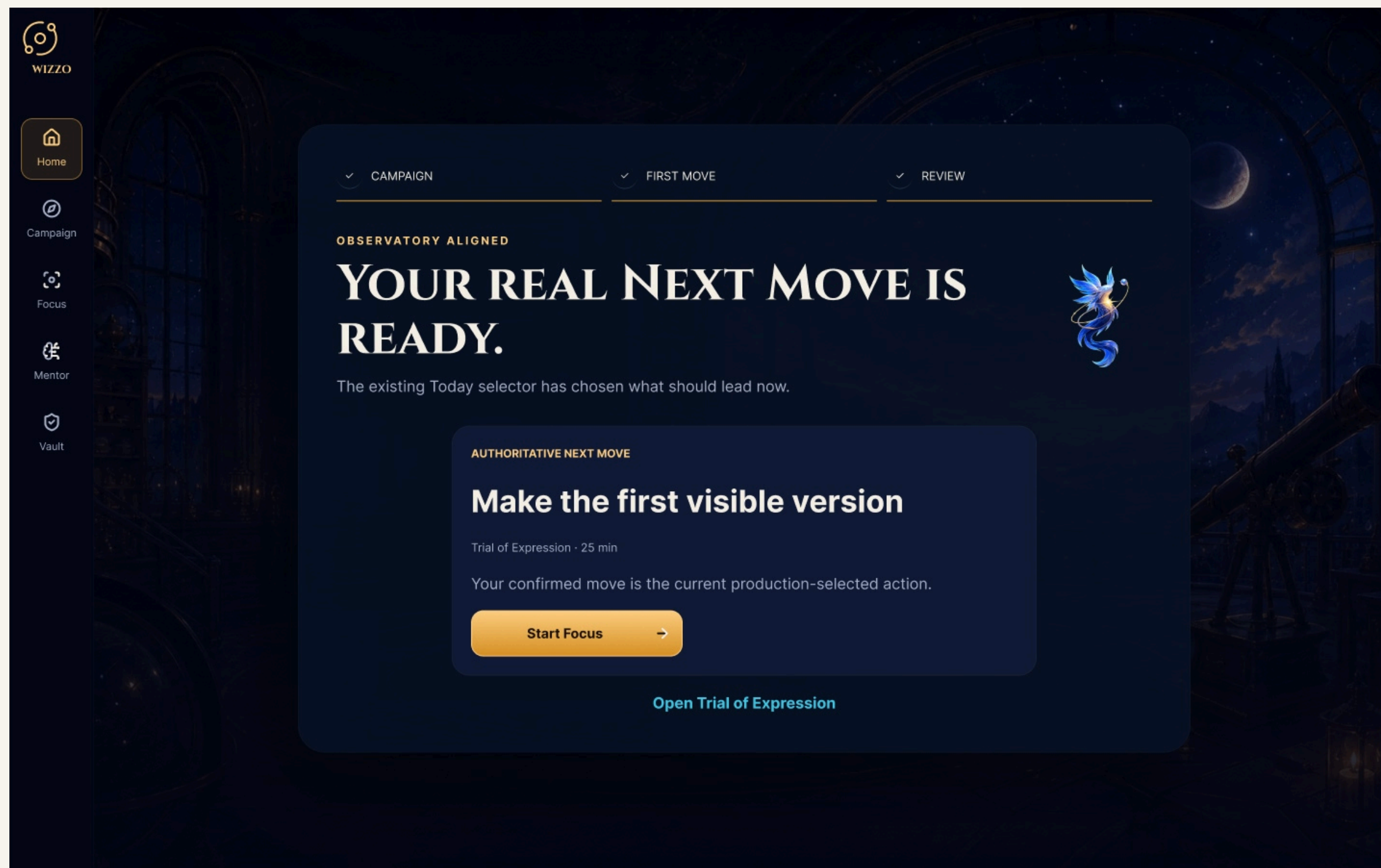
State that the move was not saved.

Recover

Provide a specific retry and retain the edit path. Error text and placement carry meaning alongside color.

Tell the truth about the next move.

A saved action and the selected Next Move are different concepts.



Creating a first move does not justify replacing a stronger action already selected by the product. The completion experience supports both outcomes: the saved move can be the next move, or an existing move can remain the lead.

Decision

Preserve the product's real selection.

Tradeoff

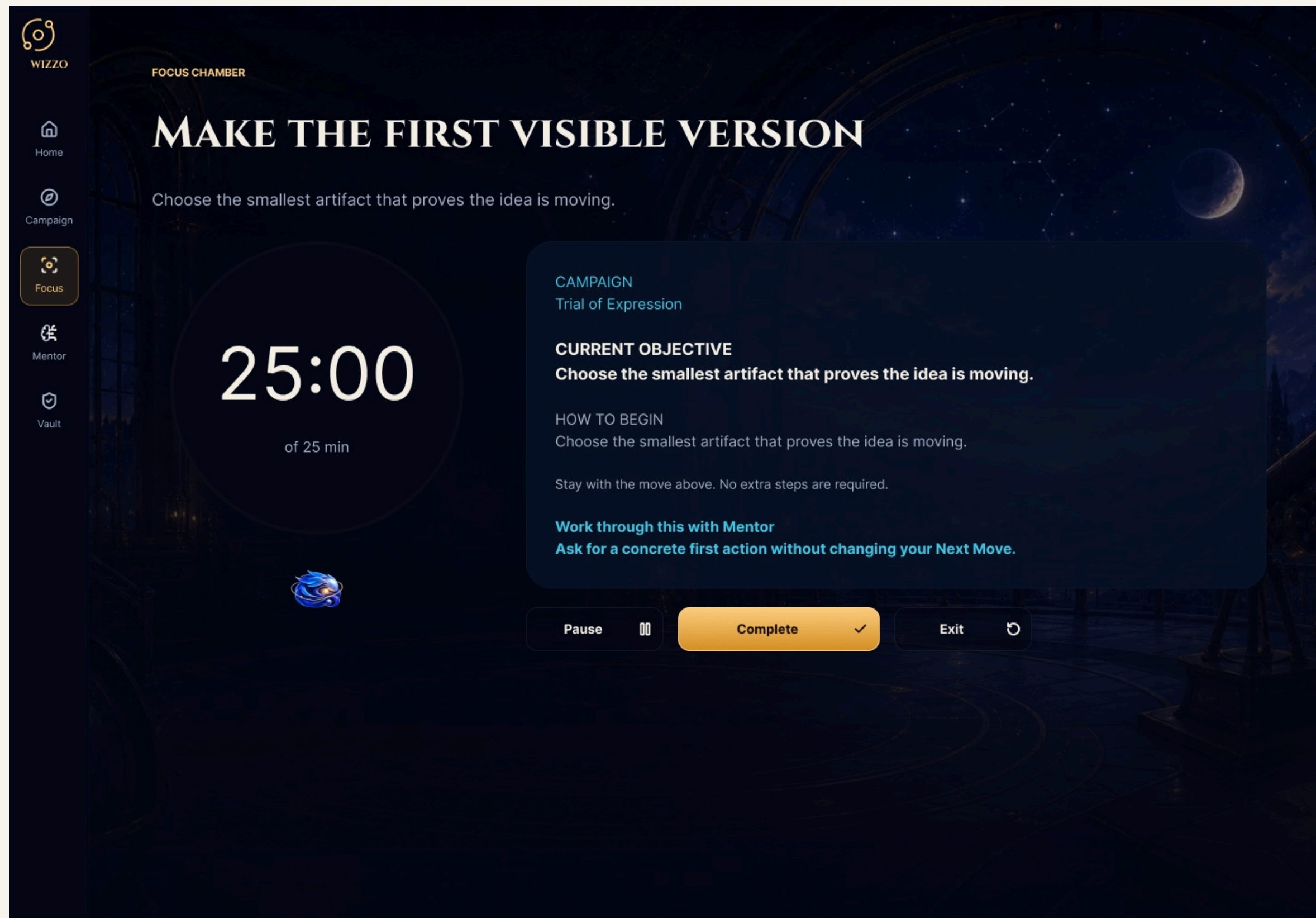
The confirmation may be less simple, but it avoids a misleading promise.

Interaction

Explain the outcome and continue into the move that actually leads.

Carry the decision into action.

Focus: a continuous task, not a disconnected timer.



Starting Focus carries the selected move and duration into a dedicated space. Campaign context remains available while the timer and current objective take priority. Pause, resume, exit and completion are explicit states.

Continuity

The action the person chose should be the action they see in Focus.

Control

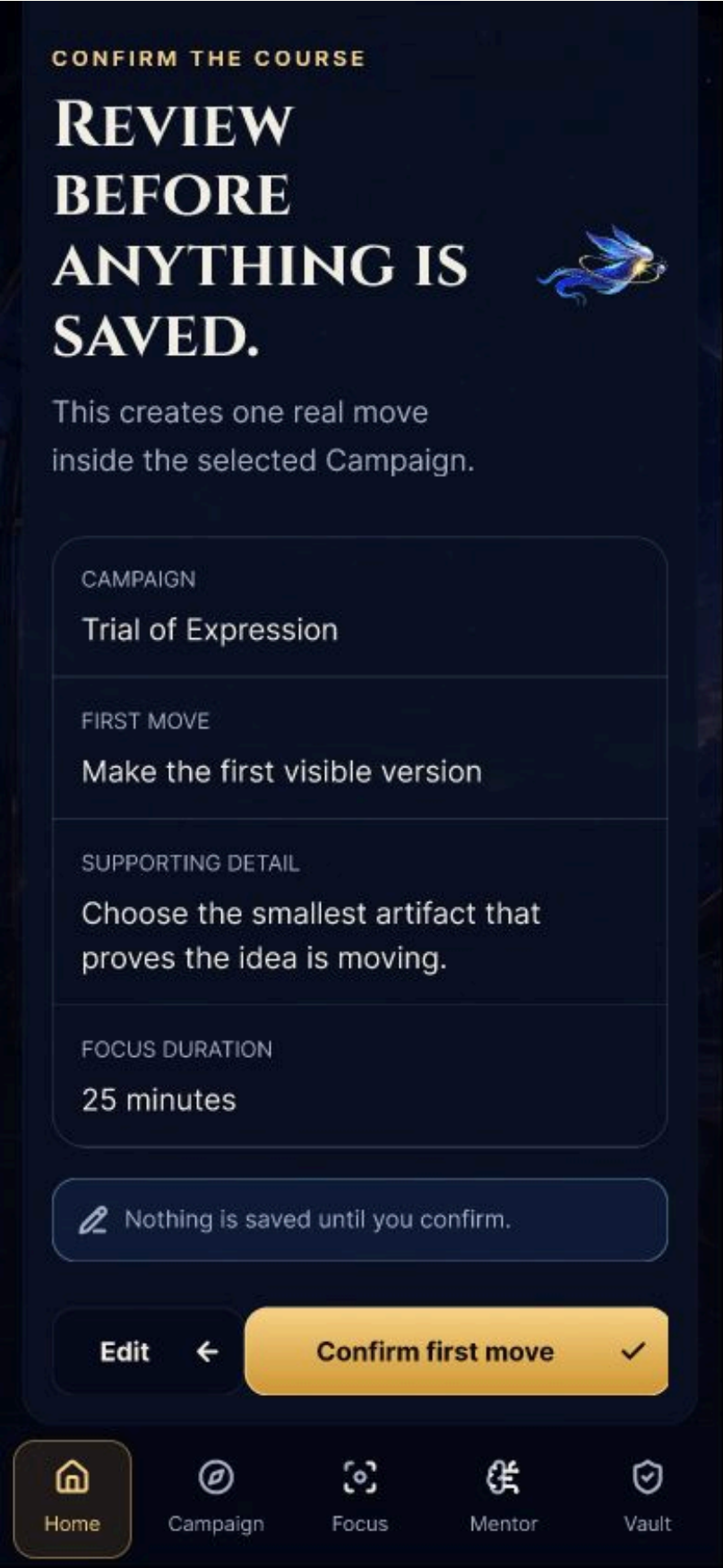
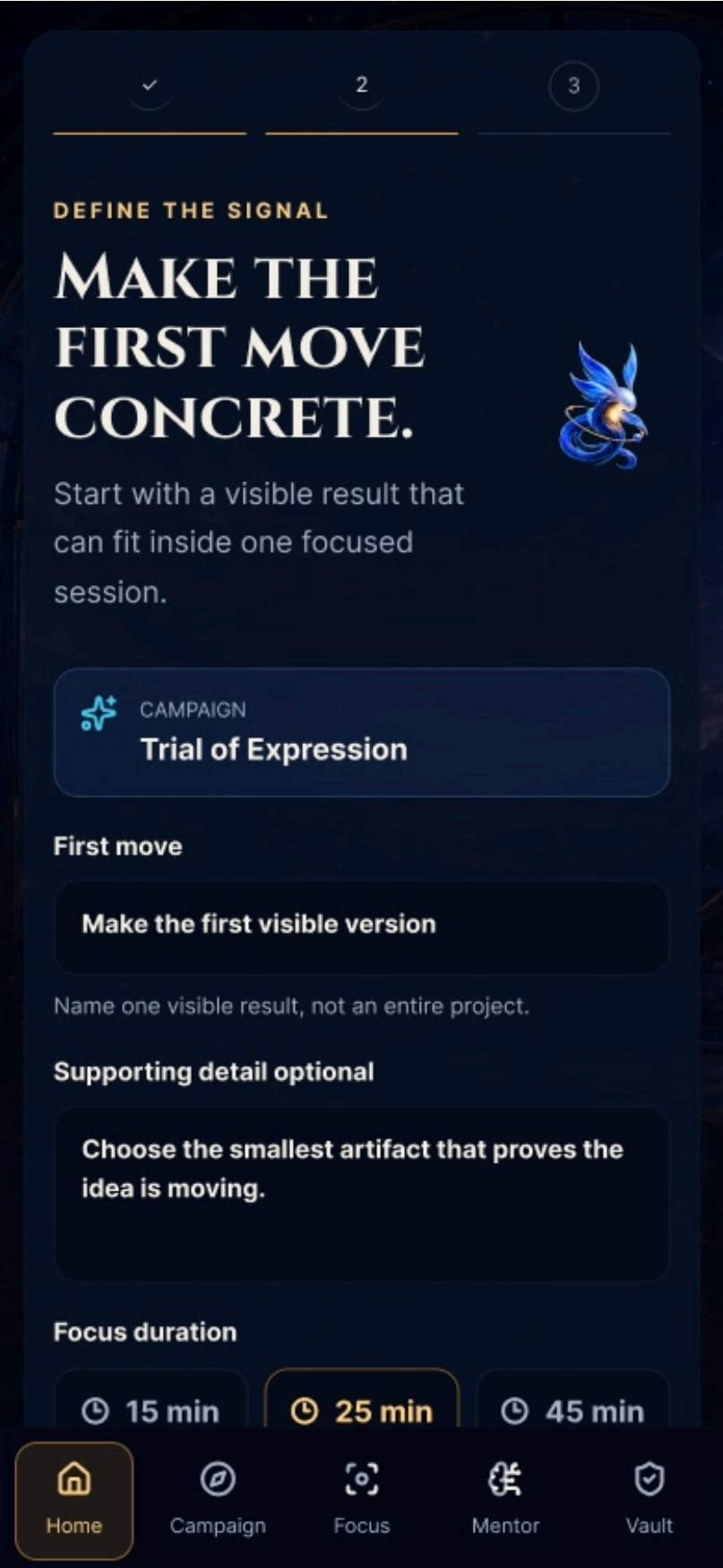
Pause and resume change state without replacing the task.

Completion

Acknowledge the result and return to the broader experience.

Keep the commitment reachable.

Mobile form and scrolled confirmation.



On mobile, a single reading column carries the form and review. Fixed navigation remains separate from the scrolling content. The continuation action belongs inside the scrollable region, with enough bottom space to be reached above navigation.

Reflow

Review labels stack above long values.

Reach

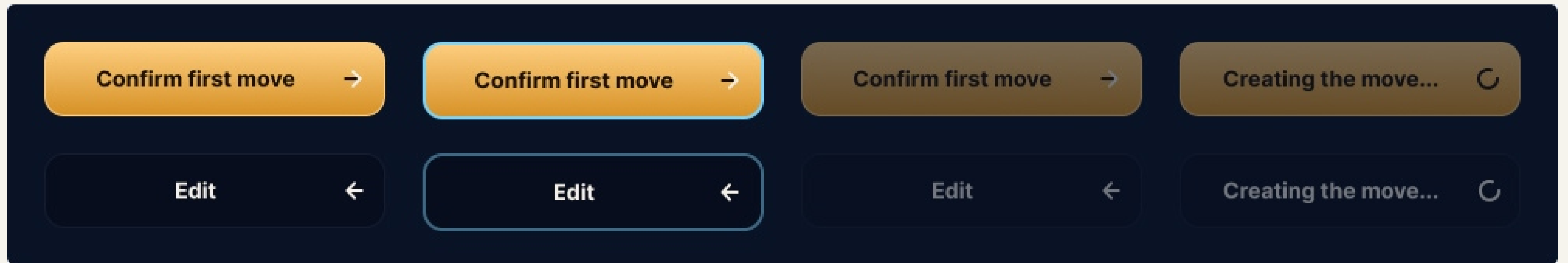
The right-hand capture shows Confirm first move above fixed navigation after scrolling.

Scope

These full screens are fixed viewport samples. Shared component instances demonstrate width-responsive behavior.

How do components preserve intent?

Reusable controls and interaction states.



A control family carries the decisions that should not vary by screen: primary and secondary hierarchy, focus treatment, disabled and busy states, icon placement and label behavior. Instances expose those choices without rebuilding the control.

Anatomy

Label + optional icon + consistent insets and minimum height.

State

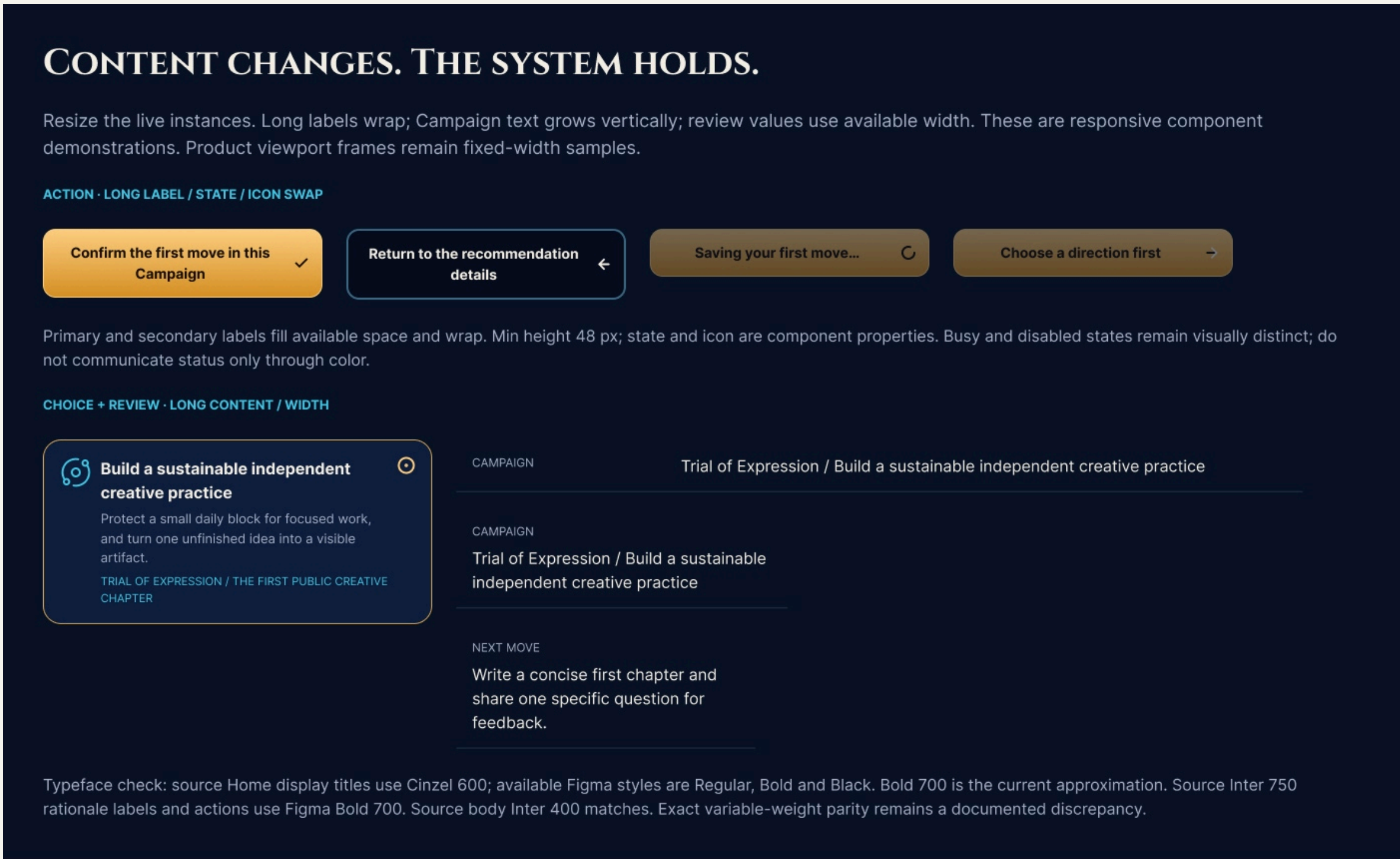
Default, focus, disabled and busy are explicit variants.

Content

Long labels wrap in the available width. The icon can be swapped without creating another button family.

Content is a design input.

Stress the system with realistic extremes.



Short labels can make a component look finished before it is robust. The stress area uses longer Campaign names, multiline descriptions, narrow review rows and action-state changes. It exposes the component rules directly as editable instances.

What changes

Text length, width, state and icon.

What holds

Readable hierarchy, sufficient control height, stable icon geometry and expanding text regions.

Review method

Resize and edit the instances, then inspect the product viewport and scrolling behavior separately.

Name the job, then bind the color.

The same palette serves different interface roles.

The system now exposes roles such as text/primary, surface/panel, border/focus and status/error. These alias the existing source palette. Component bindings use the role layer while retaining the original variables.



Canvas

#050816



Panel

#091326



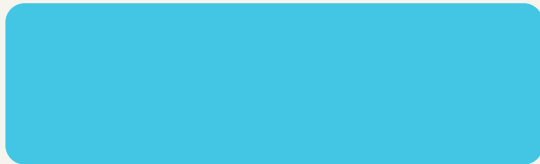
Elevated

#111c38



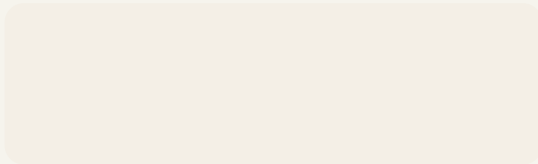
Action

#f0ae42



Context

#42c7e5



Primary text

#f5f0e6

Why it matters

A semantic role explains intent when a component changes or a new surface is introduced.

Migration

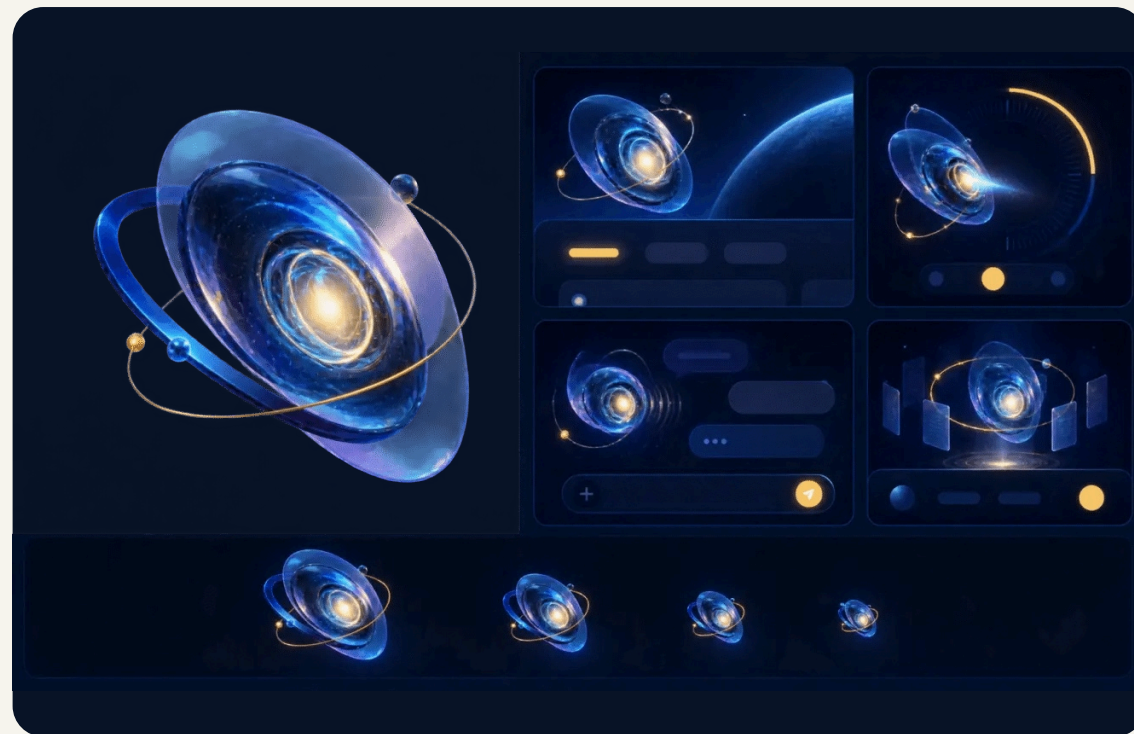
Existing variables were preserved; component bindings were inspected and updated without changing the palette.

Source mapping

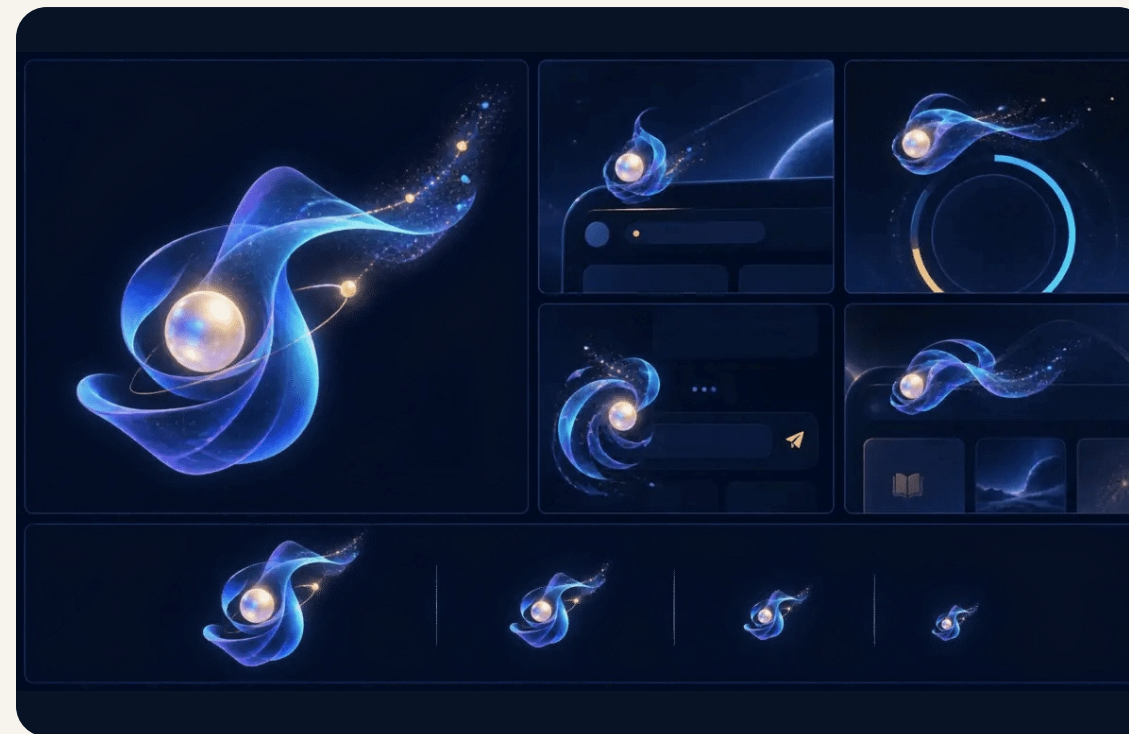
Code syntax points to the existing Observatory CSS tokens. The documentation links back to the editable component source.

A companion should belong to the world.

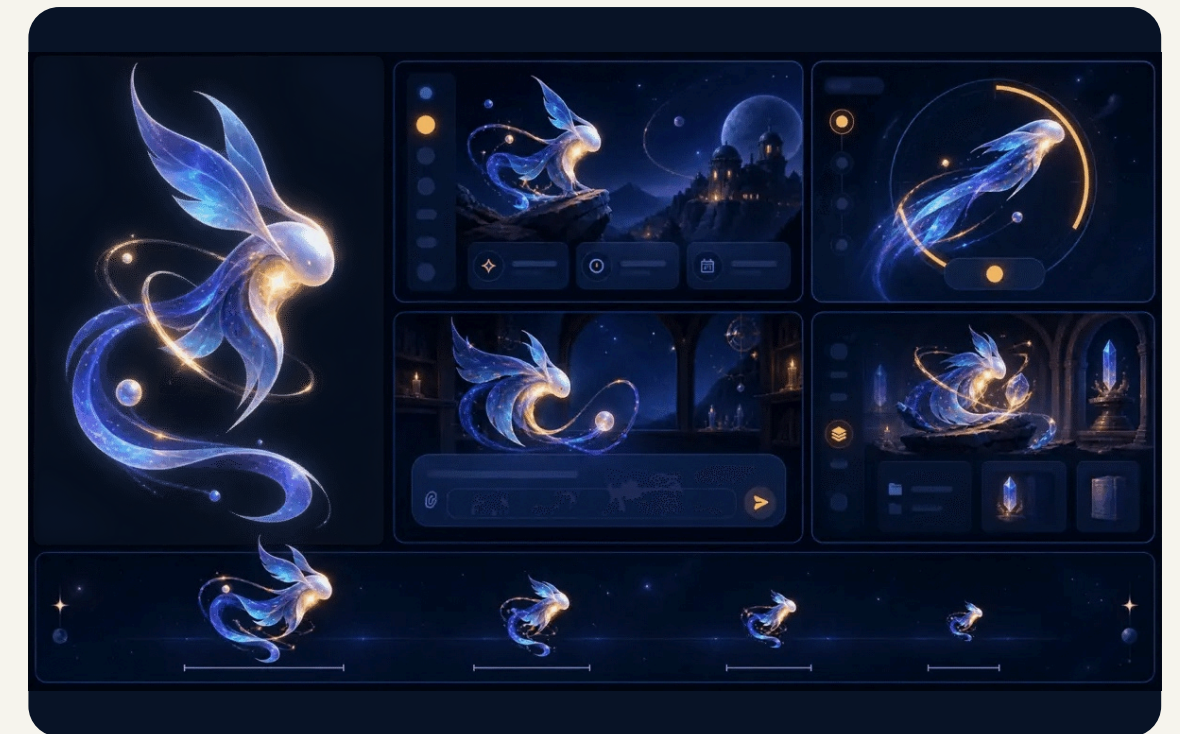
Wisp: direction, critique and a shared family.



Living Lens



Astral Ribbon



Celestial Familiar / selected

Wisp needed to read as a distinctive astral creature rather than a conventional badge or avatar. The direction studies explored Living Lens, Astral Ribbon and Celestial Familiar. I selected Celestial Familiar and asked for a more clearly mythical creature.

Selection criteria

A recognizable silhouette, warm core, restrained expression and a form that could survive smaller sizes.

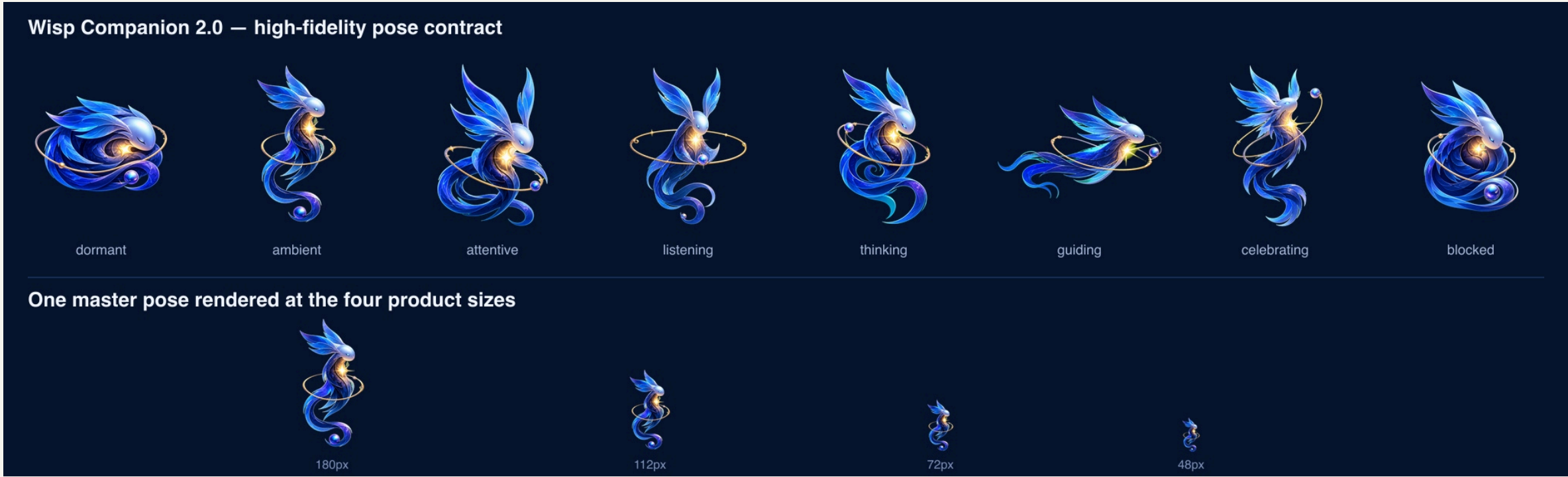
Product role

Support attention, guidance and progress without competing with the current task.

August 2026 direction studies. Celestial Familiar selected.

A valid export can still miss the design.

The acceptance bar was fidelity and state clarity.



The first simplified vector export lost the painterly character of the chosen direction and did not distinguish the poses clearly enough. I kept that result rejected. The accepted replacement used separately authored transparent pose inputs and a revised runtime authoring path.

The critique

The defining visual qualities had to survive production.

The correction

Preserve silhouette, warm core and distinct pose behavior across the family.

What is shown

The image is the accepted replacement visual contract. The rejected binary is not reproduced here.

Different states need different visual behavior.

A bounded vocabulary shared across surfaces.



Dormant, ambient, attentive, listening, thinking, guiding, celebrating and blocked states make Wisp reusable. The creature retains its identity while the pose and behavior respond to a specific product state.

Avoid ambiguity

Listening and thinking should be distinguishable; status text remains available.

Keep restraint

Celebration should acknowledge progress without interrupting the next action.

Use meaning

State comes from the interface, not an invented claim about the user's emotions.

Identity has to survive at 48 pixels.

Four size tiers, one recognizable family.



The system includes 180, 112, 72 and 48 px tiers. A large illustration can carry detail that disappears in a compact surface. The smaller tiers need a clear silhouette and stable placement before decorative detail.

Large

Expressive moments and dedicated surfaces.

Medium

Contextual presence beside working content.

Compact

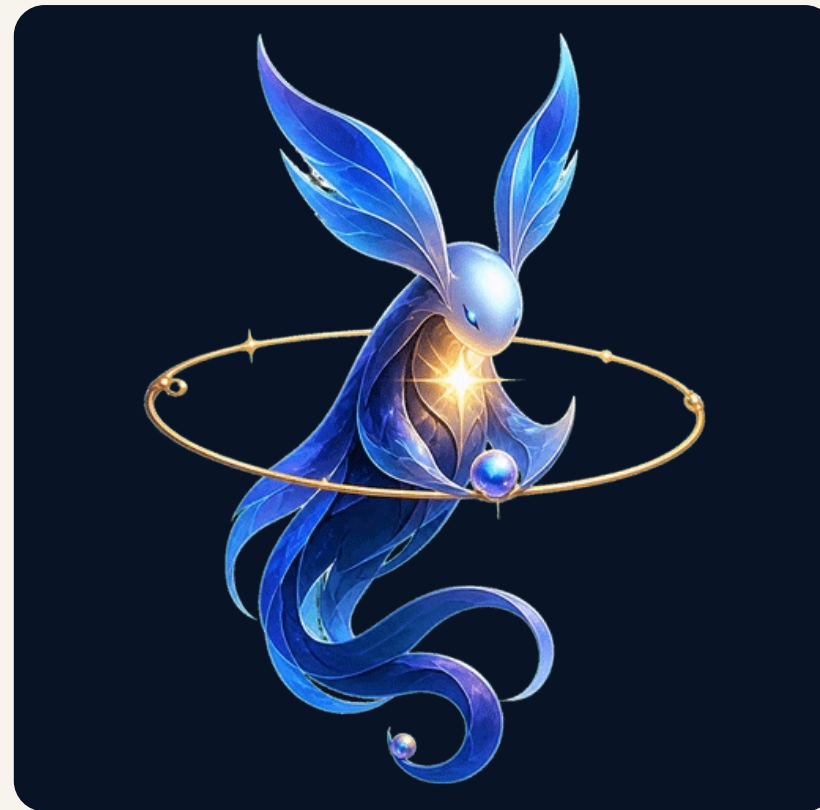
Persistent identity without consuming the task area.

The companion remains useful without motion.

State-aware static fallback.



Ambient



Listening



Thinking



Blocked

The shared Wisp component selects the runtime or a matching static fallback. Fixed geometry keeps the layout stable. Reduced motion and failure to load the animated runtime must not remove essential information.

Illustrated here

Ambient, listening, thinking and blocked fallback assets.

Accessible behavior

Pair meaningful state with text. Treat purely decorative artwork as decorative.

Continuity

The same state vocabulary survives runtime changes, reduced motion and static rendering.

Human judgment defines what gets accepted.

Constraints, exploration, critique, revision and reuse.



AI-assisted production helped explore and scale the Wisp assets. The design work was defining the direction, identifying what the export lost, and requiring the replacement to satisfy a shared visual and behavioral contract.

Direction

Choose the creature language and set the visual constraints.

Critique

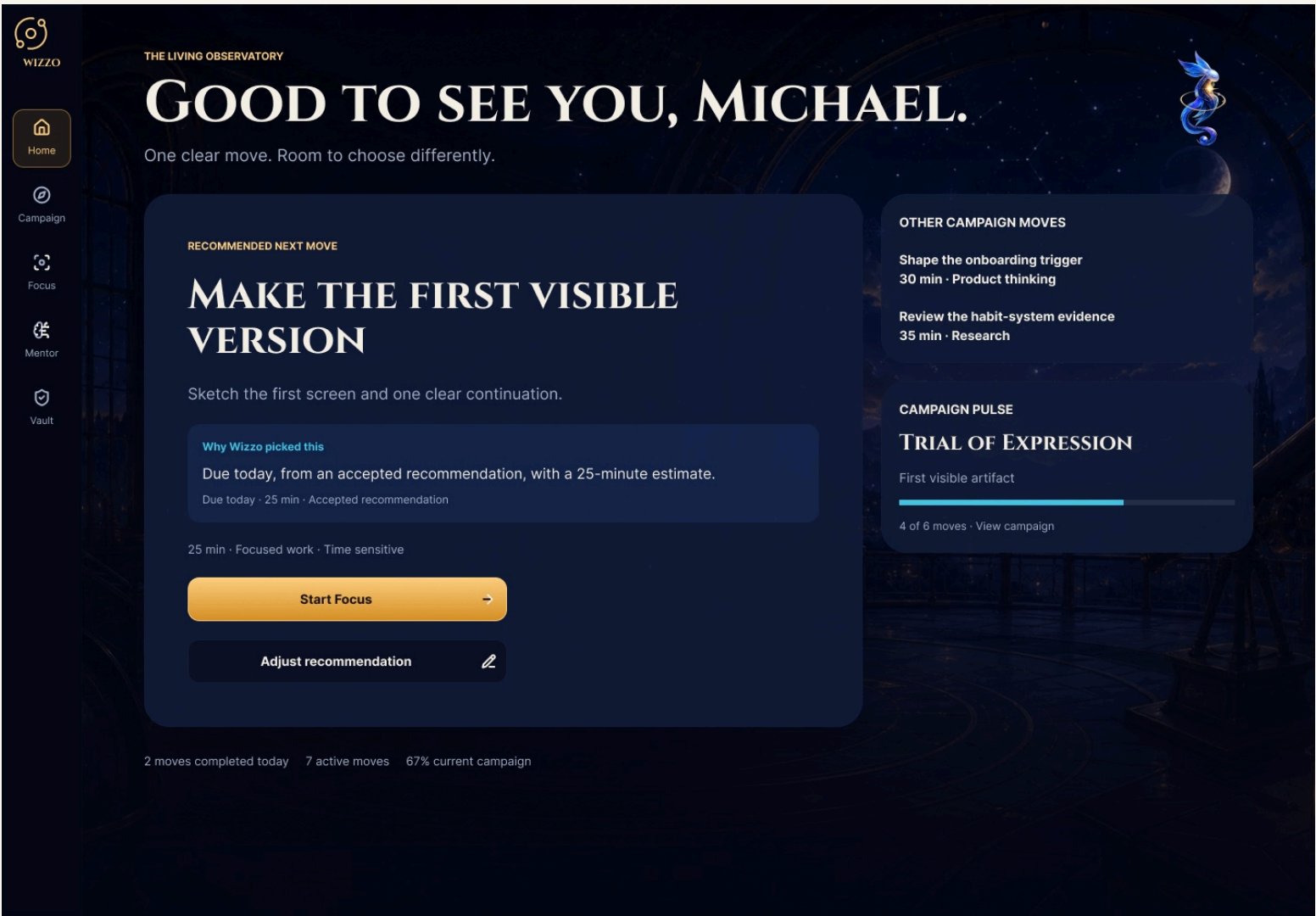
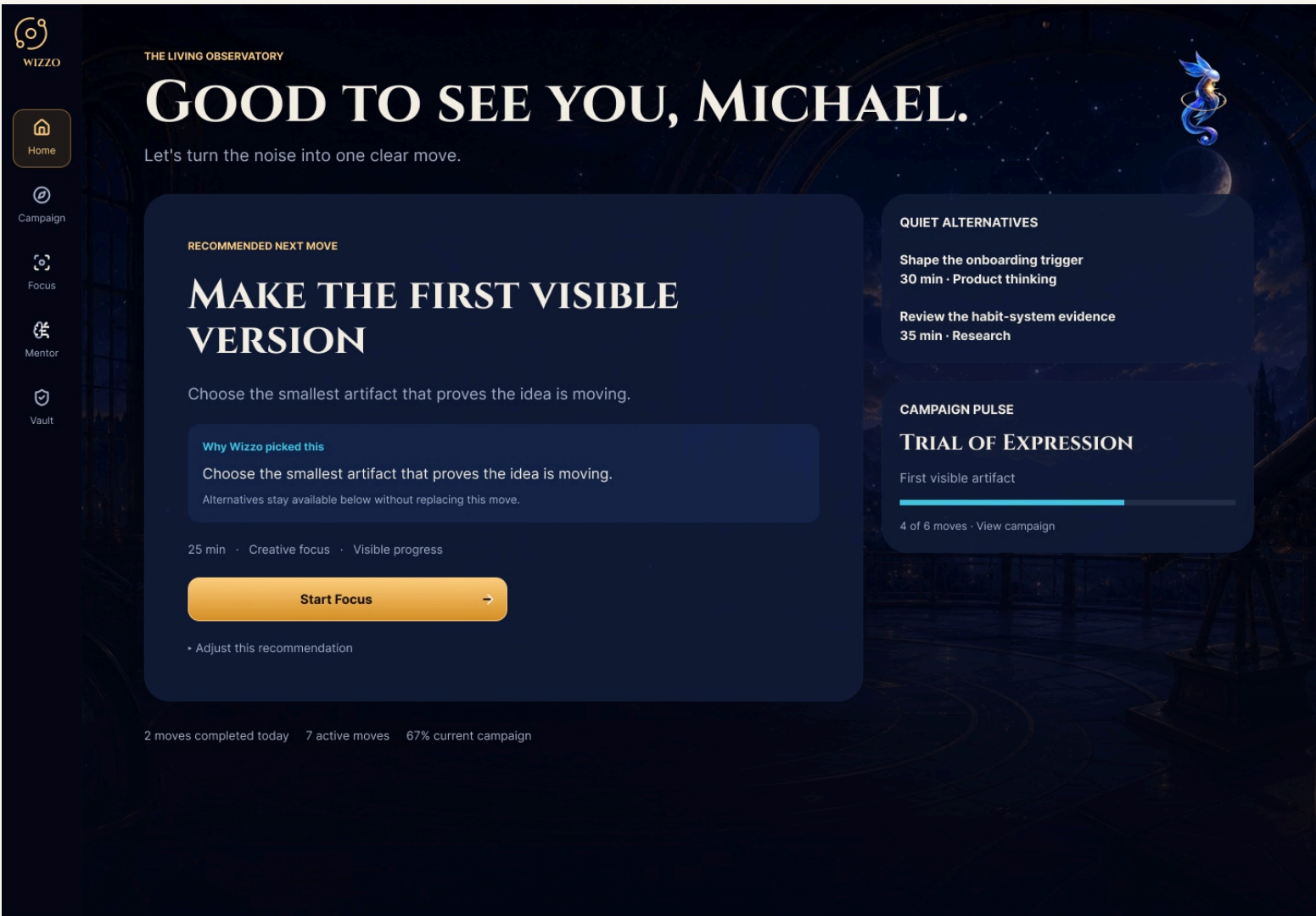
Reject an output that misses fidelity or pose differentiation.

System

Accept reusable inputs, runtime behavior, fallback assets and state/size coverage together.

Can the explanation help someone choose?

A new exploration, created in Figma before implementation.



The preserved Home example repeats the task instruction inside its explanation, and its adjustment affordance is outside the prototype. I used those gaps to explore a clearer reason and a complete adjustmt interaction.

Content distinction

Task guidance explains how to begin.
Recommendation reasoning explains why this move leads.

Source constraint

Use supported fields such as due date, duration and accepted-recommendation context.

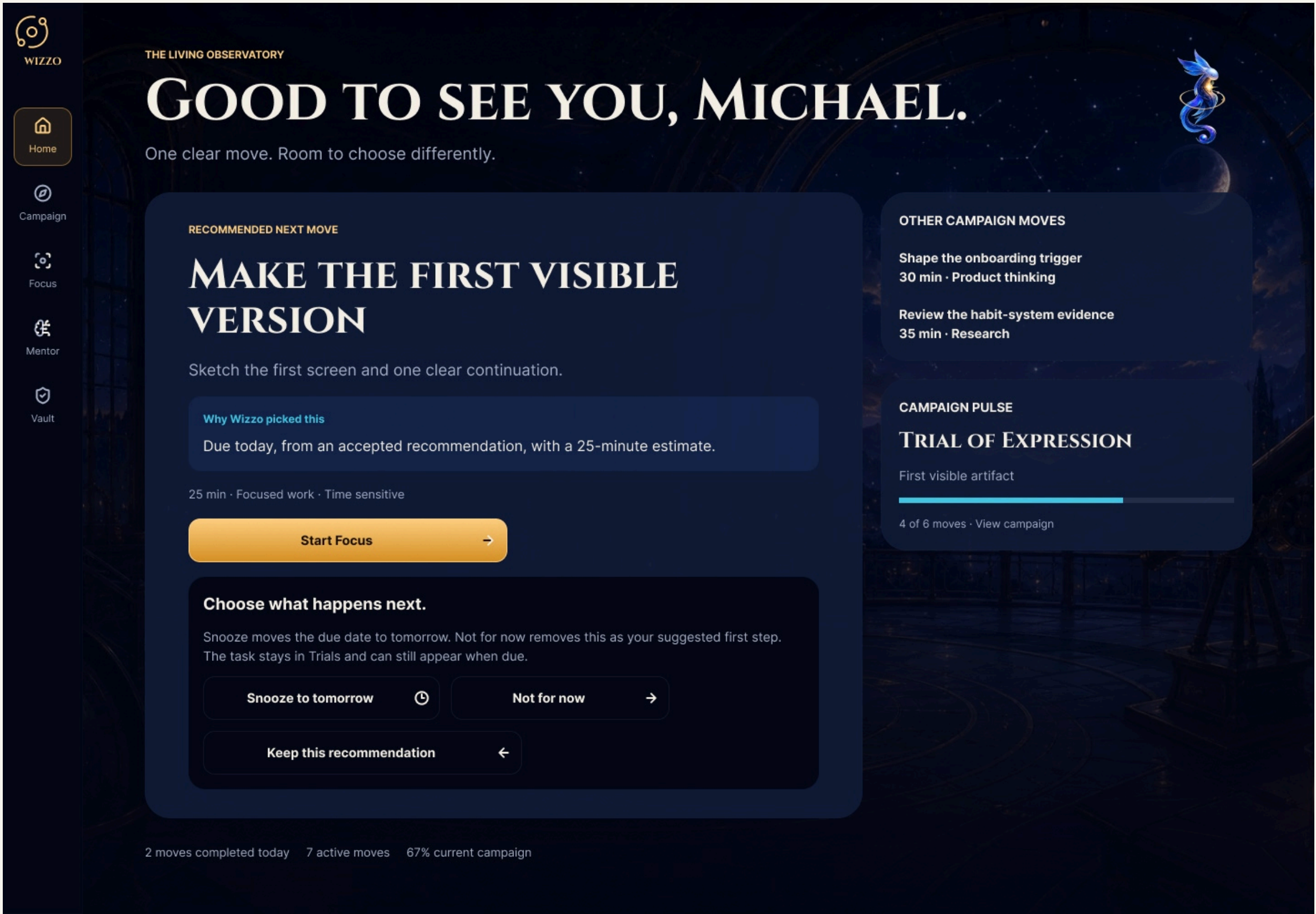
Status

New proposal pending review. No production change.

Preserved baseline / New proposal A. Illustrative task and account data.

Keep the reason beside the task.

Inline explanation and expanding adjustment.



The reason stays visible before and during adjustment. Snooze moves the due date to tomorrow. Not for now removes this as the suggested first step. The task stays in Trials and can still appear when due.

Strength

The task, reason and consequences share one context.

Cost

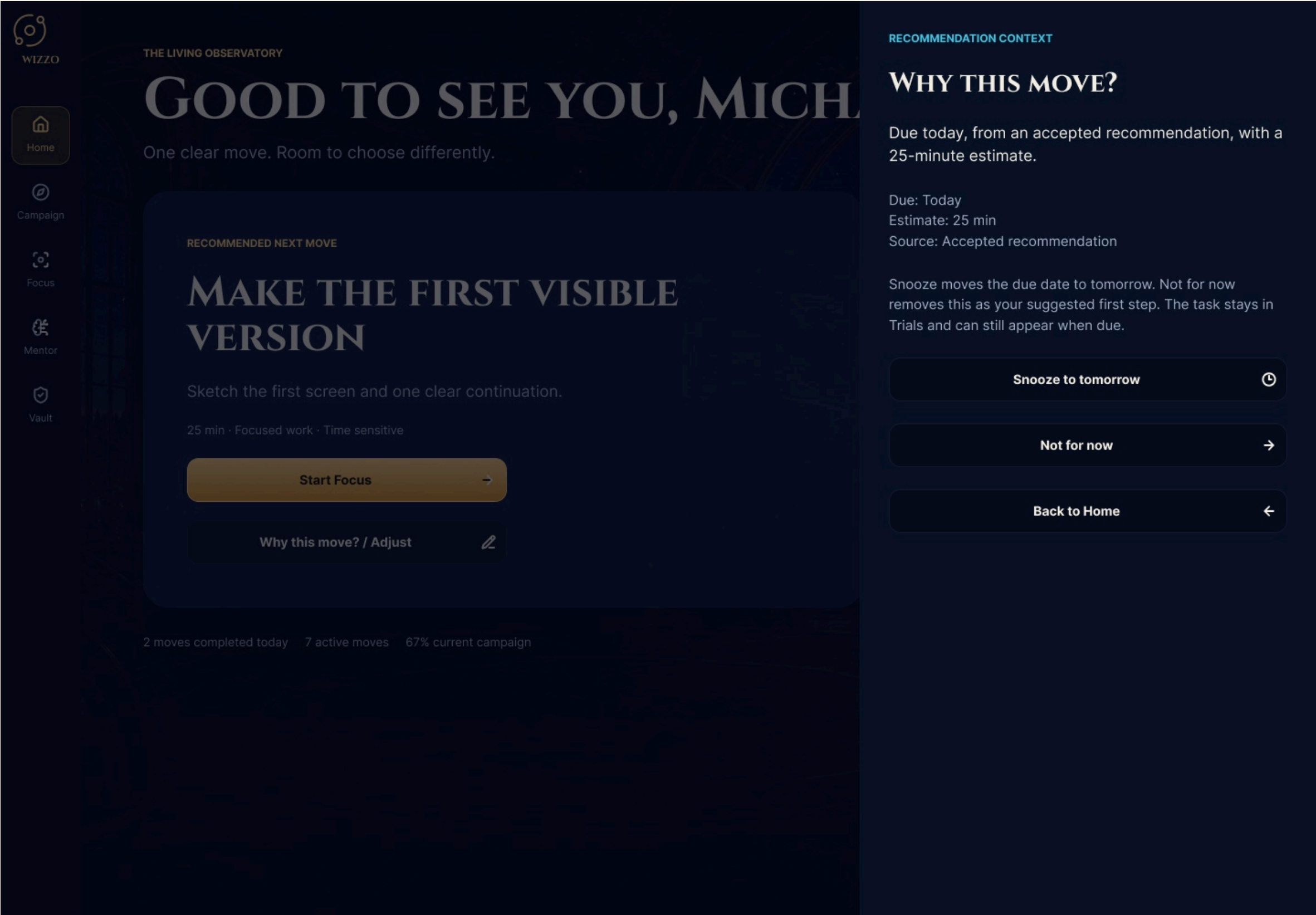
The card becomes longer when expanded. Inspect the linked 360 px scrolling layout study.

Best fit

A small number of frequent, understandable adjustments.

Give context its own space.

A quieter Home with a dedicated drawer.



The second option opens reasoning and adjustment in a side drawer. It has more room for context and future controls, while the Home card stays compact.

Strength

A focused place for deeper explanation.

Cost

An extra step and a layer over surrounding work.

Decision

Keep as the alternative. Prefer inline for the current two-action scope.

Choose on interaction cost, not novelty.

Alternative A is recommended pending Mike’s review.

For two simple adjustments, A keeps the reason and controls beside the task. Its cost is a longer card. B offers more room but adds a context switch. Use the same scenario to evaluate both before implementation.

Comprehension

Can someone explain why this move leads without repeating the task instruction?

Control

Can they predict what Snooze and Not for now will change?

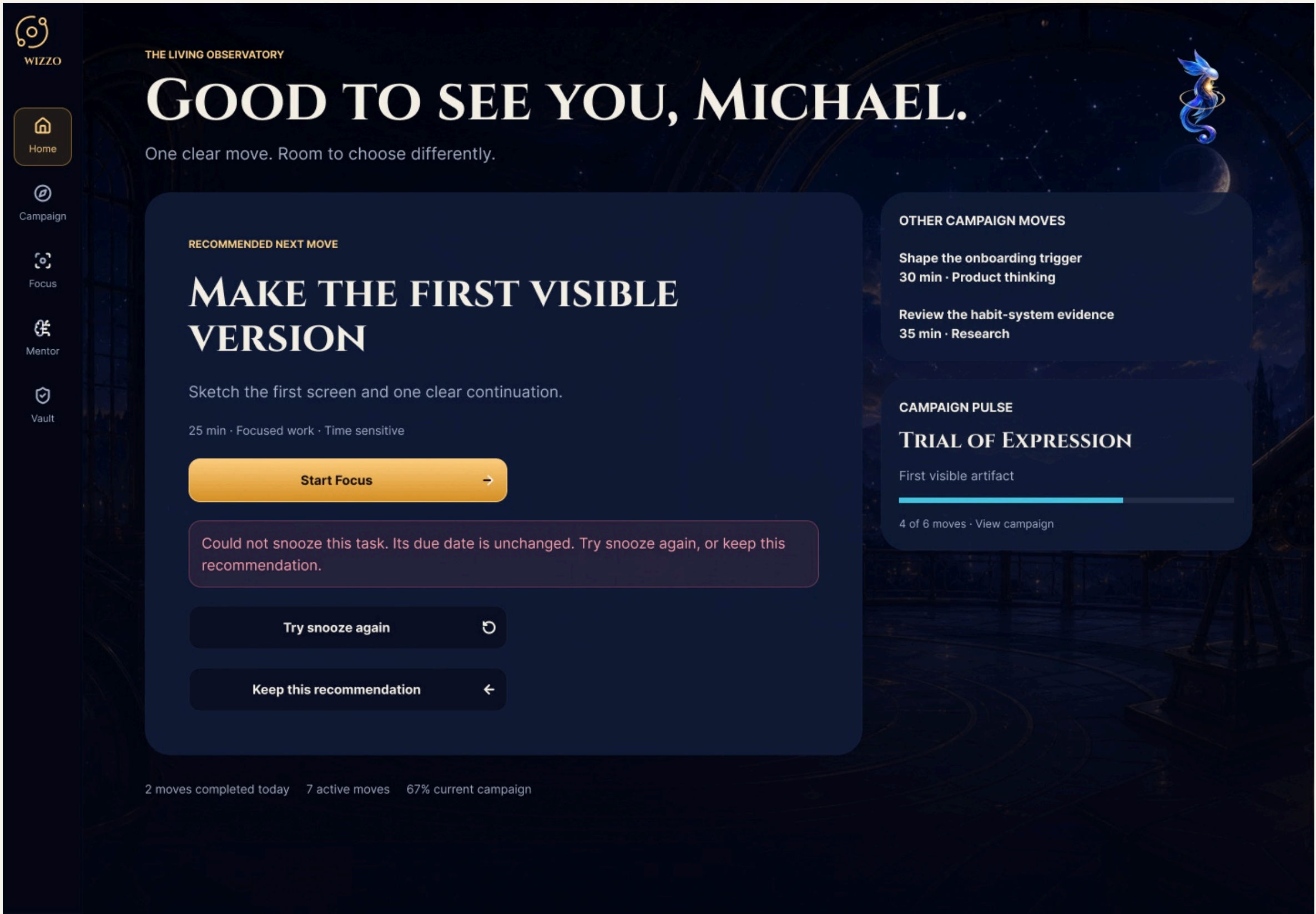
Continuity

Can they keep the recommendation, recover, and return from Focus to the same alternative?

Decision criteria for planned evaluation. No comparative test result claimed.

An adjustment needs a complete ending.

Confirmation, cancellation, failure and reset.



The proposal connects the adjustment choices to confirmation states and an error-recovery path. It names the result without pretending to know which move a refreshed queue will select. Reset is explicitly a prototype control.

Snooze

Confirmed: due date changed to tomorrow.

Not for now

Removed as the suggested first step. The task stays in Trials and can still appear when due.

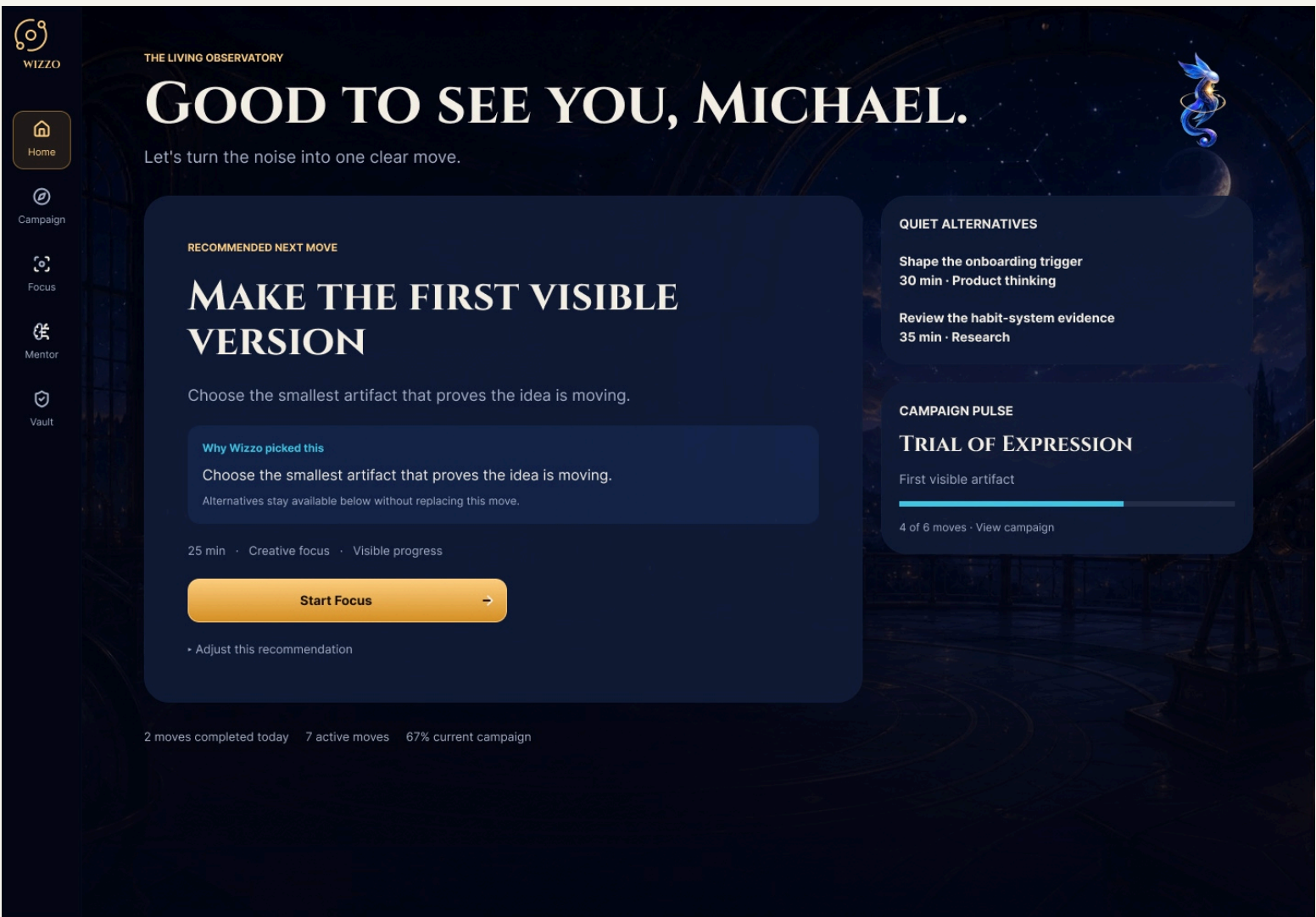
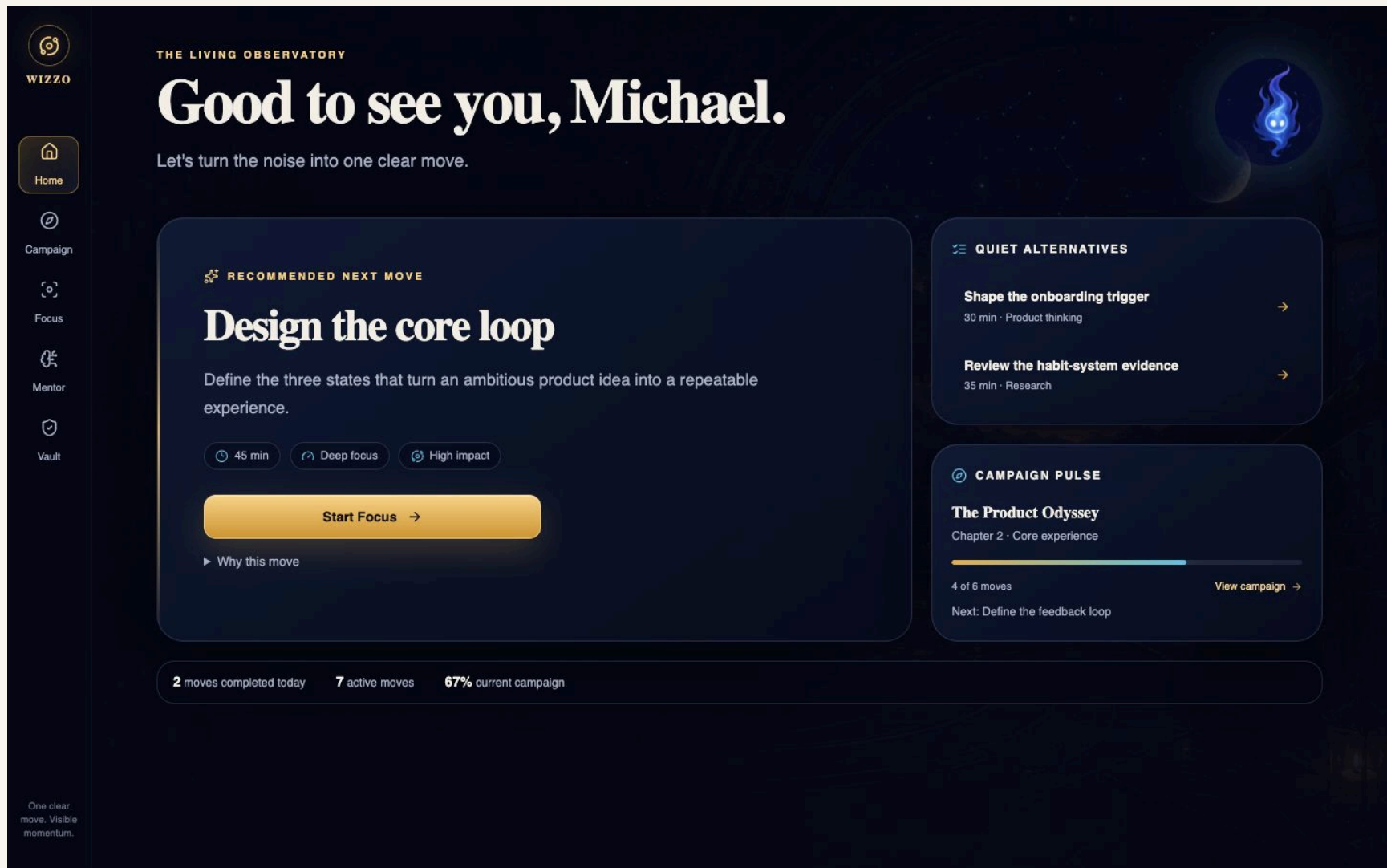
Failure

Due date unchanged. Try snooze again inline, or keep the recommendation.

Prototype simulation. Retry control is proposed, not implemented.

Keep historical and current views legible.

Historical and current Home views.



The July Home artifact keeps the explanation behind disclosure. The current Home makes its rationale visible. The new exploration strengthens the content distinction and connects adjustment. Those are different states of the work and are labeled accordingly.

July artifact

Earlier Home hierarchy and earlier Wisp.

Current system

Visible recommendation explanation and reusable native controls.

New exploration

Inline and drawer proposals awaiting review.

Does clarity turn into useful action?

The next questions are behavioral.

The resulting experience has a clearer hierarchy, a consistent visual identity, explicit commitment and designed recovery states. The next evaluation should establish whether those decisions help people understand and complete useful work.

Comprehension

Ask a person to explain the recommendation and predict each adjustment consequence.

Activation

Observe direction selection, review completion and a first Focus start.

Recovery

Introduce a failed save and an adjustment failure; check whether the person can continue independently.

Separate activity from meaningful progress.

Planned measures and guardrails.

A click on Start Focus is an intermediate action. The useful outcome is a person beginning and completing work they still consider relevant. Measurement should connect the steps and preserve the distinction between observed behavior and causal improvement.

Primary sequence

Confirmed useful action, Focus start and completion.

Diagnostic signals

Edit and cancellation rates, reason comprehension, recovery success and abandoned starts.

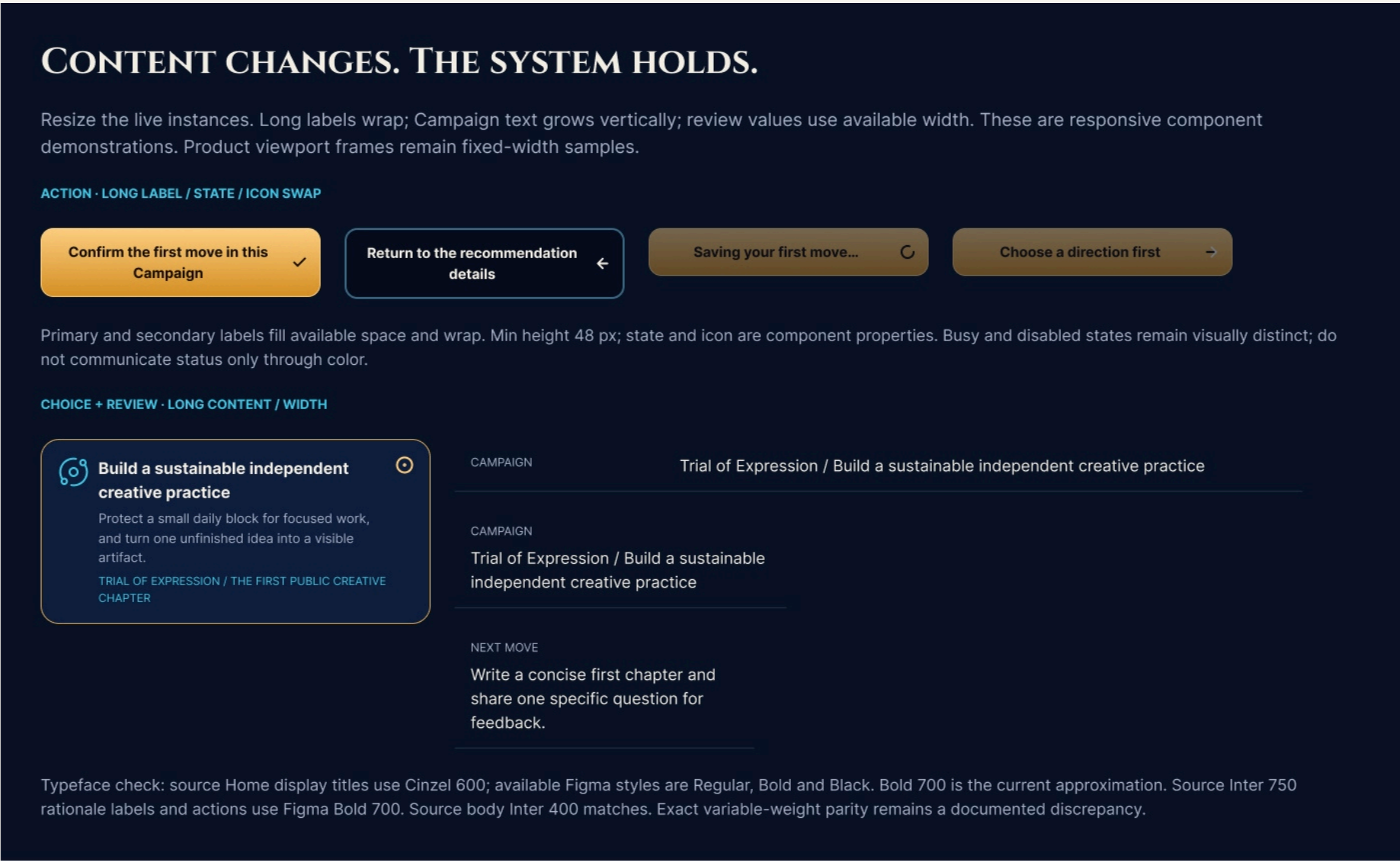
Guardrails

Do not reward accidental confirmations, irrelevant recommendations or repeated restarts. Compare cohorts only when the design and measurement support the question.

Evaluation plan. Conversion, retention and causal lift are not established here.

Open the system. Follow the interaction.

The decisions are available as editable artifacts.



The product file contains native screens, component sets, variables and prototype connections. The documentation file holds editable case-study and guide pages. The guides explain how the same rules appear in the implementation.

Product

Home, onboarding, review, completion, recovery and Focus.

System

Action, choice, field, duration, step, feedback, review row, navigation and Wisp families.

Documentation

Brand applications, semantic roles, anatomy, responsive rules, accessibility and source mapping.

A short note on what you are seeing.

Enough context to interpret the work.

Product frames use illustrative task and account data. Historical images carry dates. The Home alternatives are new proposals pending review; other frames describe the existing experience. Figma interactions simulate behavior and are not application tests.

Motion

Static pages show pose and size behavior. Runtime animation and reduced-motion behavior require application testing.

Data

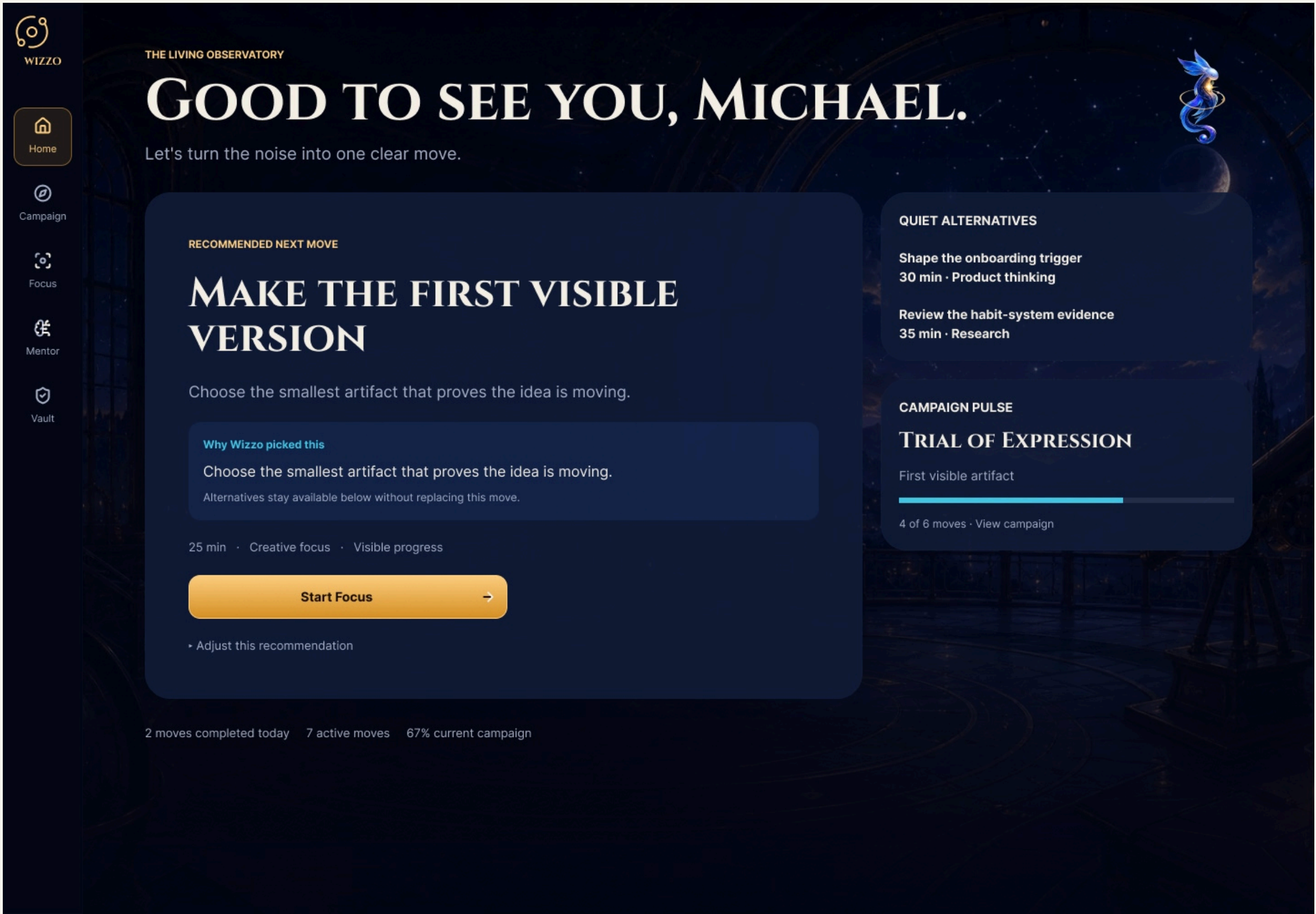
Task names and account values are illustrative examples, used consistently across the prototype.

Evaluation

Prototype checks establish interaction continuity. User comprehension and product impact remain evaluation priorities.

A recognizable experience with deliberate control.

A clear task, a coherent world and reusable rules.



Wizzo now expresses the direction I wanted: an ambitious goal becomes one concrete move, the person can understand and change the commitment, and the visual system carries that intent across screens and states.

Clarity

One dominant action, with context in a supporting role.

Agency

Editable review, explicit confirmation and recoverable failure.

Coherence

A shared component system and a distinctive Wisp family. The next step is evaluating how well people understand and use it.